

helps reduce fevers by stimulating perspiration. The root is also taken for the treatment of chronic diarrhea and dysentery.

Related Species *A. incarnata* and *A. syriaca* have both been used in Native American herbal medicine to treat asthma.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. Excessive doses may cause vomiting.

Aspalathus linearis (Fabaceae) Rooibos, Red Bush

Description Variable shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m) in height, with green, needle-like leaves, yellow, pea-like flowers, and small seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern South Africa, rooibos is now widely cultivated as a commercial crop, particularly in the Cedarberg mountain area. The seed is hard to germinate and must first be scarified. The young leaves are harvested once a year, chopped, and left to “sweat” or ferment before being dried.

Parts Used Young leaves.

Constituents Rooibos contains polyphenols, including flavonoids, with a low tannin content.

History & Folklore Rooibos was first used as an appetizing tea by the Khoisan people, indigenous to the Cedarberg region, but also as a sleep aid and for headaches.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Drunk mostly as a pleasant tasting, caffeine-free drink, rooibos, like green tea, has significant antioxidant activity. There is evidence to suggest that the fermented leaves exert a protective effect on the heart and circulation. In view of the herb’s traditional use, it might also prove helpful as a nighttime drink to promote sound sleep.

Asparagus officinalis (Liliaceae) Asparagus

Description Slender-stemmed perennial growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has long fronds of delicate needle-like leaves and bell-shaped yellow-green flowers that produce small bright red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to temperate regions in Europe, North Africa, and Asia, asparagus is cultivated worldwide as a vegetable. The shoots grow into tender green (and, if sheltered from sunlight, white) stems in spring. The root is gathered after the shoots have been cut.

Parts Used Root, shoots.

Constituents Asparagus contains steroidal glycosides (asparagosides), bitter glycosides,

asparagine, and flavonoids. Asparagine is a strong diuretic.

History & Folklore To judge from ancient Egyptian tomb drawings, asparagus was cultivated as long ago as 4000 BCE. In the 1st century CE, the Greek physician Dioscorides recommended a decoction of asparagus root to improve urine flow and to treat kidney problems, jaundice, and sciatica.



Asparagus is used to treat a range of urinary problems.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Asparagus is a strong diuretic that is useful for a variety of urinary problems, including cystitis. It is also useful for rheumatic conditions, helping to “flush” waste products accumulated in the joints out of the body in the urine. Asparagus is also bitter, mildly laxative, and sedative.

Caution Do not take if you suffer from kidney disease.

Asparagus racemosus (Liliaceae) Shatavari, Indian Asparagus

Description Slender perennial fern growing to 23 ft (7 m) in height. Shatavari has fronds of needle-like leaves, tiny white flowers, and purple-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Himalayas and the Indian subcontinent, shatavari grows wild in gravelly soils up to 3,900 ft (1,200 m) above sea level. It is also found in western China.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Shatavari contains steroidal saponins, alkaloids, and mucilage.

History & Folklore Shatavari is known as the “Queen of herbs” in Ayurvedic medicine. Its name literally means “100 spouses,” signifying the herb’s ability to act as a sexual tonic and promote fertility.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A key Ayurvedic remedy, shatavari is first and foremost a women’s herb, aiding fertility and promoting conception, and

acting as a general reproductive and sexual tonic. Shatavari can prove particularly helpful in easing menopausal symptoms, such as hot flashes and poor stamina. It appears to improve fertility in both men and women, and may also be taken to treat impotence. A tonic, strengthening herb, shatavari supports immune function and has a place in the treatment of immunosuppressed conditions.

Related Species Asparagus (*A. officinalis*, see preceding entry) is a relative.

Asperula odorata syn. *Galium odoratum* (Rubiaceae) Sweet Woodruff

Description Perennial growing to 18 in (45 cm). Has a square stem, whorls of narrow elliptical leaves, and small white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Sweet woodruff is native to Europe, and is also found in Asia and North Africa. It grows in woodlands and shaded places.

The herb is gathered when in flower in late spring.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Sweet woodruff contains iridoids, coumarins (0.6%), tannins, anthraquinones, and flavonoids. The flavonoids act on the circulation and are diuretic.

History & Folklore When it dries, sweet woodruff takes on the scent of newly cut grass, and it has often been placed between clothes to impart its aroma. In his *Irish Herbal* of 1735, K’Eogh records that “It is good in healing wounds if bruised and then applied, and also in curing boils and inflammations.” In Germany *Maiwein*, made of sweet woodruff steeped in white wine, is drunk to celebrate May Day.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sweet woodruff is considered tonic, with significant diuretic and anti-inflammatory effects. Its coumarin and flavonoid constituents make it helpful for varicose veins and phlebitis. It has been used as an antispasmodic, and it is given to children and adults for insomnia.



Sweet woodruff aerial parts are dried for medicinal use.